Looks Matter

This year we have seen remarkable improvements in the design of TFT-LCD monitors. Dual-toned, double-hinged, adjustable heights, pivots and touch sensors, were some of the features we encountered in this comparison test.

Along with performance and features it is important to consider appearance and build quality. Since beauty lies in the eye of the beholder, you can get an idea about the "looks" of every monitor we tested from the thumbnails placed under our comparison table. As for their build quality, you have to actually see one to best judge it. Some models paid attention to such design aspects and some of them were just plain, and there is thus nothing better than touching and feeling a unit personally. Let's take a look at the striking models in each category.

15-inch

There was very little variance in appearance under the 15-inch banner. Most of the models were the generic single hinge type, meant for tilting the monitor screen about the horizontal axis, with a simple black-silver colour combination. The LG Flatron L1520B stood out as the better-looking 15-inch monitor with its aesthetic design. The heavy, steel circular base assured that the monitor stayed put on the desk. The NEC AccuSync LCD52V was the only single-tone (dark grey) LCD monitor in the lot.

17-inch and 19-inch

This is where all the *masala* was to be found. Many of the design features, such as double-hinge and pivot, were common to both 17- and 19-inch displays; as such, we have clubbed these together.

BenQ, with its FP72V 17-inch unit, steals the limelight in its category. Its combination of ivory-white and grey exteriors along with speakers, a double-hinge mechanism and an integrated Web cam make it the most stylish monitor in its class.

None of the other 17-inch monitors had a double-hinge like the BenQ FP72V, but they differed in styling. For example, the New Universe (NU) monitors had a thin metal border as the frame to its screen, and others such as Acer, Gigabyte and LG retained the slim, bezel appearance. The Asus PM17TU sported a glossy or mirror-finish on its front face.

At first glance, you can easily pick apart the Asus PW191 from its 19-inch brethren. Its black piano-finish casing, enclosing the touch sensor panel, and its WXGA widescreen was very striking indeed. Its heavy base and stand made up of aluminium exemplifies superb build quality. Thanks to a pivot head located at the back of its screen, you can rotate it by 90-degrees to portrait mode. If you are impressed by the description so far, we advice you to read our full review as appearance is only the first impression.

The Acer AL1916W and the CMV CT-937A were other 19-inch widescreen monitors. The latter has a design that resembles the Nokia 7610 mobile phone with one sharp corner and the other rounded. We also liked the ViewSonic VX922 for its simple yet classy design.

Usually, the stand is made up of double-hinge (such as the one found in the Asus PW191 and the BenQ FP72V) by which the screen of the monitor can be moved up and down as a height adjustment feature. But NEC engineers have intelligently managed space by employing adjustable height without the use of second hinge. Two concentric rectangular box form the stand of the screen. The outer box moves up and down while the inner one is fixed to the base of the stand. A click is heard when the maximum height is reached. A user can choose any height between the maximum and minimum, and the screen will rest in that position until forcefully moved. Apart from this unique feature, the NEC monitors were plain-looking, with a dark-grey exterior.

power rating of the LCD you plan to purchase, and note whether there is a substantial power saving to be had with a different model. This might not make much of a difference to a home user, but in an office where a lot of monitors are deployed, the power costs will add up and most certainly make a difference.

In the 15-inch category, the NEC, NU and Samsung had a power consumption rating of 25 W each—the lowest in this group. The Philips 170S had the lowest power consumption in the 17-inch category. Even amongst the 19-inchers, the Philips 190V boasted of the lowest power consumption—34W—closely followed by the ViewSonic VX922, at 35W.

A Look At Performance

The monitors were tested using display benchmark utilities—DisplayMate Video Edition and the Passmark monitor test utility, along with several real-world tests. These included the viewing angle test and looking for the ghosting effect under movies.

Sharpness And Resolution

We checked for the sharpness of images using the Point Shape and Visibility screen in DisplayMate. This test displays fine white dots against a black background. We observed the screen for pixel bleeding, and found that most monitors had some amount of bleeding at the edge. Bleeding results in a red, green or blue tinge at the edge of a pixel dot. We found the Samsung SyncMaster 740N in the 17-inch category the best in this test.

BenQ FP72V

In the video bandwidth test, a fine white line is drawn on a black background. This test is used to see how accurately the lines are drawn, and whether there are any discrepancies in their geometry or characteristics.

In the 15-inch category, the Gigabyte GD-1503B displayed blue tinges running across the length of the line at the edge. This was also the case with the NEC AccuSync LCD72V under the 17-inch category and the NU L921G and the NEC MultiSync LCD1970NXp in the 19-inch category. This test is important for people who use imaging software, where accurate reproduction of finer elements is of prime importance.

The Samsung SyncMaster 540N in the 15-inch category, the Samsung SyncMaster 740N in the 17-inch category and the BenQ FP91V in the 19-inch category were found to be the best in their class. We must stress that we did not find